Gopal who is believed to have suggested to Rahul that he should target the 'Not Rich, not Middle class, not BPL' (referred to as NRMB) constituency, sandwiched between poverty and middle-class incomes. This idea would lead Rahul in the 2014 elections to seek out the unorganized sector social groups like street vendors, farm labour and daily wage earners as a potential vote bank (see chapter 8).

Gopal has an interesting CV. He was one of the founders of the Congress's student wing, the NSUI, in the 1970s. He even became president of the NSUI between 1974 and 1976 before leaving party politics to do a law doctorate at Harvard, then work for twenty years in legal administration at the World Bank and then head the prestigious National Law School in Bangalore.

I met Gopal for this book and asked him to describe his relationship with Rahul. 'No, I am not an adviser or mentor to Rahul, I am only a colleague,' is how he described the equation. He claimed that Rahul had 'genuine empathy and goodwill for the poor' and was looking to provide them with a *dhancha* (support). 'Long before Aamir Khan discovered Bezwada Wilson and the *safai karmachari*s in *Satyamev Jayate*, Rahul was already in dialogue with them on what needed to be done for manual scavengers,' claims Gopal.

I wondered whether the kurta-clad Gopal had drawn Rahul into the NGO–*jholawallah* circuit, in a sense, and thereby retarded his political growth. 'I think that is a spurious argument. Don't forget, a political party is also an NGO that is meant to serve the aam aadmi,' he countered.

Rahul, though, clearly seemed to lead two lives. In the day he would engage with thinkers and activists, but at night he seemed to draw comfort from being in the company of family friends from the glamorous Page Three set. Perhaps the India–Bharat divide was most in evidence in his own personality, a split he was perpetually trying to reconcile both with himself and with his view of India. Delhi's gossip bazaars would endlessly speculate on who his latest girlfriend was and on the mysterious foreign trips he would often take off on. I found it amusing that every year in June when Rahul celebrated his birthday, the Congress faithful would line up